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Hausa theatre in Niger

Author(S): Beik, Janet

Document Type: Book

Original Page: 118

Culture (OWC): [Hausa \(MS12\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Western Africa

Field Date: December 1980 - November 1981

Coverage Date: 1976-1981

Place Coverage: Niger

Section Title(S): The Maradi Troupe

What requires several pages of transcription for the dialogue alone from the performance-- such as a series of greetings when a new character enters-- may not appear at all in the text or may be reduced to one line. For example: "Bonjour, Mademoiselle, il est là votre patron?" in the written play represents several minutes of flirtation in performance. The young man enters, greets the secretary, remarks how beautiful she looks today, asks if she is going to the party that evening. She replies that she would like to go but that she needs a new dress; he asks how much it would cost and gives her the money for it. She then says that her mobylette is out of gas and she cannot use it; he gives her the rest of his government gas coupons, and she agrees to meet him at eight o'clock. He then asks if her boss is in and she directs him to go on inside the office (Scene 5, Dan Kwangila). (⁸³) The written line in French  ¹¹⁹ apparently recorded for the troupe the sense of this brief interaction: two educated people in an office (who both speak French), the bit of business to carry the scene further ("Is your boss in?" being the young man's reason for appearing). Yet equally a part of the scene, although unwritten, was the joking rapport between the young people, the coy requests of the secretary and the man's compliance, which earns him immediate access to her employer. The mixture of Hausa and French in the actual performance of this scene came naturally to these actors, a probably unconscious portrayal of conventions in real life (when and where Hausa is appropriate in an office, what signals a joking relationship/flirtation, etc.). Their precise lines in this dialogue most likely varied from one performance to another, despite the troupe's insistence that they do not improvise, but the key points of action and speech would remain the same (in that sense it is a "set" text).

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Dan Kwangilaa, mimeographed text by the Maradi Theatrical Troupe, 1981, Scene 5 (shaahii na biyar), p. 12. (The line is in French in the original, with "Mademoiselle" abbreviated "Mlle"). The performance description is from an audio tape of the troupe's performance in

Diffa, Niger, 9 April 1981, transcribed by Aboubacar Mahamane. (The dialogue in performance is a mixture of **Hausa** and French).

Human Relations Area Files

755 Prospect Street

New Haven, CT 06511

General Inquiries:  hraf@yale.edu

Issues and Bugs:  hraf-support@yale.edu



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